UTTAR PRADESH

★ **BRAJESH PATHAK**
From: BSP to BJP in September 2016
USP: A former BSP MP, he played a critical role in forging Dalit-Brahmin unity for Mayawati. Is deputy CM in UP and is the BJP's predominant Brahmin face

★ **SATYAPAL SINGH BAGHEL**
From: BSP to BJP in 2017
USP: Was a BSP Rajya Sabha MP since 2014. Was formerly close to Mulayam Singh but a soured relationship with Akhilesh Yadav led to his exiting the party. He is now a minister in the Modi government

RITA BAHUGUNA JOSHI
From: Congress to BJP in 2016
USP: A former state PCC chief, she switched to the BJP before the 2017 polls. She is now the party's MP from Allahabad. Her brother and former CM of Uttarakhand Vijay Bahuguna also joined the BJP. Her nephew Saurabh Bahuguna is minister in the Pushkar Singh Dhami government

JITIN PRASADA
From: Congress to BJP in June 2021
USP: A former Congress MP, he was in the core group of Rahul Gandhi. He is now PWD minister in Uttar Pradesh

NAND GOPAL GUPTA
From: Congress to BJP in January 2017
USP: A former BSP legislator and confidant of Mayawati. Contested the Lok Sabha polls from Allahabad as a Congressman. Now minister for industries in UP

NARENDRA BHATTI
From: SP to BJP in November 2021
USP: Formerly Mulayam Singh's pointsman in western Uttar Pradesh and a dominant Gurjar leader, he is now a BJP MLC

CHAUDHARY LAXMI NARAYAN
From: BSP to BJP in 2015
USP: An influential Jat leader and six-time MLA, he has been associated with the Lok Dal, the Janata Dal, the Congress and the BSP

★ **KAUSHAL KISHORE**
From: Rashtravadi Communist Party to the BJP in 2014
USP: Formerly an MoS in the SP. Has a deep network and is widely accepted among Dalits in eastern UP

UTTARAKHAND

SATPAL MAHARAJ, VIJAY BAHUGUNA, SUBODH UNIYAL, SARITA ARYA, KISHOR UPADHYAY
From: Congress to BJP

DELHI

MANOJ TIWARI
From: SP to BJP

RAJASTHAN

GHANSHYAM TIWARI
From: Congress to BJP

★ Union Ministers


Satpal Maharaj

A tabulation by the Trivedi Centre for Political Data at Ashoka University shows the BJP gave assembly poll tickets to 833 turncoats in the last decade, and 44 per cent of them got elected. This story is, thus, a key component of how the BJP has ended up with 1,387 out of a total 4,120 legislators in assemblies across India. It's also translated into the BJP and its allies ruling in 17 states, covering over half the country's population.

The frequent floor crossing by legislators is not a random process. There's a specific pattern and direction. A key index of how India's politics is loaded these days lies in the fact that, while some 462 also moved out of the saffron fold, only 14 per cent of those won thereafter. The Trivedi Centre's data shows that, after the BJP, the Congress attracted most defectors—517—but only 20 per cent won thereafter. Similarly, the BSP received 196 defectors, but with a less than 4 per cent conversion rate to victors, and the Samajwadi Party followed with 167 and 22 per cent. Leaving out the variations, the rough equation goes like this: the BJP grew, the Congress bled. The Grand Old Party haemorrhaged the most, with one-third of its defectors winning on other party symbols. It needs no data scientist to conclude that it was most likely the lotus. The story remains mostly the same for other parties. But there's one outlier, in the shape of the Trinamool Congress. The doughty Mamata has done a BJP on the BJP, having already poached former Union minister Babul Supriyo and saffron renegade Shatrughan Sinha, who even went on to win the Asansol Lok Sabha seat. The TMC has wrested a total of seven faces from the BJP, including the prize catch of Mukul Roy. But broadly, the patterns hold: the lotus is far and away the dominant species in the pond.

A LOTUS-SHAPED PLAN

If all of the above conjures up the picture of a ravenous, omnivorous predator indiscriminately trawling the ocean-bed scooping up prey, nothing could be further from the truth. "A very conscious and cautious effort goes into the process of inducting someone into the party," BJP president J.P. Nadda tells INDIA TODAY. "We make

A KEY INDEX OF HOW INDIA'S POLITICS IS LOADED THESE DAYS—WHILE **SOME 462 ALSO MOVED OUT OF THE SAFFRON FOLD,** ONLY 14% WON THEREAFTER